

AN EXAMPLE OF DUNGEON DESIGN: THE HAUNTED KEEP (1st Level)

Note: This section is a step-by-step example of how to design a dungeon. THE HAUNTED KEEP can help show a new DM how to design a dungeon. Part of this dungeon is already designed, and enough other details are provided so the DM need not "start from scratch". If this sample dungeon is to be used in play, the players should *not* read the following section. The letters (A-F) correspond to those used in the guide (page B51) and illustrate each step in turn.

A. CHOOSE A SCENARIO: "In the distant past, the Haunted Keep was the castle of the Rodemus family. It was abandoned many years ago when the family mysteriously disappeared. It is now rumored to be haunted. Strange lights and sounds are often seen and heard in the ruins by passing townspeople.

"Recently, a tribe of goblins has been raiding the countryside. On their last raid they captured a dozen prisoners. The prisoners are all relatives of the player characters, who have banded together to rescue their relatives. The party has tracked the goblins to the Keep or castle, right up to the only door to the east tower.

"Most of the Haunted Keep is in ruins. Only two towers remain, connected by a gatehouse, and only the first floors of these towers are still intact. The Keep was built with rough granite blocks, now pitted with age. The door into the east tower is wooden and one hinge is rusted through."

(The three paragraphs above serve as an example of the type of information that the DM might design and read to the players to give them the background of the adventure before it begins. The DM should also write notes describing the dungeon further, giving information which would not be read to the players:)

What the players do not know is that the Rodemus family has become a family of wererats, and still live in tunnels under their old castle. The family has joined the goblin raiders and are using them to find the strengths of the surrounding countryside. If the raids show the country folk to be weak, the family plans to raise a goblin army and attack. The players will slowly discover this information, little by little, as the adventure proceeds.

B. DECIDE ON A SETTING: A "keep" is a kind of castle. The HAUNTED KEEP has two towers connected by a gatehouse. The upper stories have collapsed, and the buildings now have only one floor. The rest of the castle is totally in ruins. The insides of the two towers should be similar, though not exactly the same. The gatehouse is split into two sections, divided by what was once a main road. The interior of the gatehouse will be similar to the towers, though there will be fewer rooms (see the dungeon maps on page B57).

The catacombs (2nd level of the dungeon) are a series of caverns and crypts where the Rodemus family ancestors are buried, and lie under the ruins. The 3rd level, under the catacombs, is the maze-like lair of the Rodemus family of wererats. The prisoners will be scattered throughout all of the levels; however, the most important prisoners must be rescued from the center of the wererat lair.

C. CHOOSE SPECIAL MONSTERS: The most common monsters on the 1st level are goblins. Other common 1st level monsters are giant rats (possibly hunted by giant ferrets), bandits, and hobgoblins. Common monsters in the 2nd level catacombs are ghouls, zombies, skeletons, goblins, hobgoblins, and giant rats. Common monsters on the maze-like 3rd level are wererats, hobgoblins, bugbears, and thouls, plus at least one wight and one doppleganger.

D. DRAW THE MAP: To make it easier to draw and map, the towers are designed square rather than round. Since the east tower is small, the scale chosen is 1 square = 5'. The first thing needed is an entrance from the 1st to the 2nd levels. This is a trap door in the middle of a tower, so the first room drawn is room #4. The trap door leads to a winding staircase and eventually to the catacombs. The next area drawn is the entrance to the tower itself. The outer walls are 10' thick. Rather than have the goblins post a guard at the entrance door, a pit trap is placed in the entranceway. Then the other rooms are drawn in, being careful to make sure that the player characters will have to go through several other rooms to each room #4 (no matter which way they go). Finally, the DM decides to make room #4 contain hobgoblins guarding 2 prisoners, room #5 will be a goblin barracks, and room #9 will be a goblin lookout post. Having no preference as to what monsters, treasures, or traps go in the other rooms, they are stocked at random.

E. STOCK THE DUNGEON:

Room 1: First the DM rolls 1d6 to determine the room's contents. The result is a 5, so the room is empty of monsters and traps. The DM rolls again to check for treasure; the result of 4 indicates that the room has none. The room is totally empty of monsters, treasures, and traps.

Room 2: The DM rolls a 2 when checking for contents, so there are monsters present. Using the **Wandering Monsters** table (level one) and rolling 1d20, the result of 16 indicates that they are crab spiders (Treasure Type U). The monster description states that 1-4 crab spiders normally appear, so the DM rolls 1d4; the result of 1 indicates that 1 crab spider is present. Rolling 1d6 to check for treasure, the result of 2 indicates that treasure is present. Rolling d% and referring to the **Treasure Types** table, these are the results:

Treasure Type	Listing for Type "U"	Dice Roll	Result
Pieces of copper	10% 1-100	21	None present
Pieces of silver	10% 1-100	02	Silver present
Pieces of electrum	Nil	—	No roll
Pieces of gold	5% 1-100	23	None present
Pieces of platinum	Nil	—	No roll
Gems/Jewelry	5% 1-4	59	No gems present
		14	No jewelry present
Magic Items	2% Any 1	86	None present

Separate rolls are made for gems and jewelry. The only treasure present is silver pieces; percentage dice are rolled to determine the number, and the result of 99 meant that the crab spider guards a treasure of 99 sp. The DM decides that the treasure is too small for a special trap. The stocking of this room is finished.

Room 3: The DM rolls 1d6 to check for contents; the result of 3 means that the room contains a trap. Rolling again to check for treasure, however, the result of 1 means that some booty or treasure has to be determined. Rolling d% and using the **Un-guarded Treasure** table, these are the results:

Treasure Type	Listing	Dice Roll	Result
Silver pieces	100 x 1d6	—	Silver always present
Gold pieces	50%: 1d6 x 10	76	None present
Gems	5%: 1d6	51	None present
Jewelry	2%: 1d6	90	None present
Magic Items	2%: Any 1	01	1 magic item present

Rolling 1d6 for silver pieces, the result of 4 indicates that 400 sp are present. To determine the magic item, a roll on d% gives the result of 44, indicating that a potion is left with the trapped silver